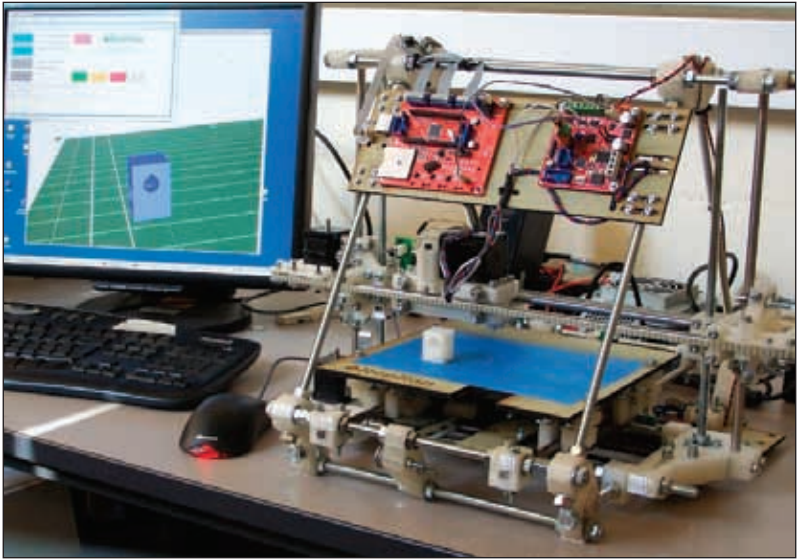




The RepRap connected to a computer.

them, and few would appreciate a settings dialog with thousands of settings, it does make Firefox a more lucrative choice for those who like to have things exactly the way they want. Now Mozilla has also launched a service for creating customized versions of Firefox for distribution within communities.

If there is anything to be learnt from the success of Firefox, it is that hackable applications can be good, and simple to use while still being powerful.

Linux has always been hackable in essence, allowing nearly every component to be replaced and modified to heart's content. After all, the OS is open source, how much more hackable could it get! This is the reason why it is popular amongst hackers and those who like fine-tuned control over their computers. For this reason, Linux has suffered as a desktop platform, as a majority of people would prefer a system which Just Works™, rather than one which Works Just the Way You Want Once You Configure It Through a Hundred Text Files™. Recently Linux has become simple enough that it works out-of-the-box for most people. Hopefully Linux will continue to become easier to use while retaining its power and hackability.

Open Source is the way to go, not just because it promotes freedom, but also because it fosters creativity. You want to know how an application works? Well, you can find out. While trying to find out how a proprietary application works will probably make you a criminal, free – as in speech –